public atmosphere in India, however, did nothing to help his attempt to convince the Chinese government of India's intentions. In May, an article in the Chinese Communist Party's *People's Daily* condemned the Indian criticism coming from the left and right and alleged a "counter-revolutionary 'holy alliance' of the Metternich type" of the US and its allies and "India's reactionary parties—the Praja Socialist Party and the Jan Sangh Party." It alleged that Nehru, an erstwhile friend of China, had been "pushed by that alliance" into singing a "different tune." Furthermore, the article criticized his "deplorable error" of blaming Beijing and sympathizing with "the little Chiang Kai-shek."[44] Subsequently, what Nehru called "a wall of silence with muffled whispers occasionally" descended from China on the subject of Tibet.[45]

The brief period of silence turned out to be the calm before the storm. In August, there were serious Sino-Indian clashes in the eastern sector of the border, which Nehru believed were "the culmination of progressive Chinese unfriendliness towards India."[46] By this time members of parliament were increasingly asking about the frontier, especially the road in Aksai Chin and China's attitude toward the McMahon Line. Parliamentarians, including first-time member of parliament and future prime minister Atal Behari Vajpayee, were unsatisfied with the government's replies and its response to alleged Chinese claims and actions. Facing significant pressure, Nehru agreed to make public a white paper on the subject.

The government went public—a departure—for a number of reasons, particularly to rebut criticism about its complacency. Dutt also saw it as a potential source of leverage with China. Earlier that year, while acknowledging that publicizing the dispute would allow the "foreign press" to "make much of" Sino-Indian differences, he had stated, "there may be an advantage in our negotiations with China to let the Chinese feel that there is anxiety in our country about the border incidents." He would subsequently note that India needed to demonstrate both the strength of the feeling in the country and the support for the Indian government to make clear to Beijing that any further intervention would "do more harm than good."[47] But the release on September 7 of the first white paper—and subsequently additional ones—had an unintended effect: rather than giving India more leverage, it constrained Nehru's freedom of action. Agitated public opinion became a potential veto point in India's decisionmaking on China.[48]